

830,000 m² of green land built over?

A newsroom's satellite estimate, tested against an independent land-cover model

THE CLAIM

“Nearly 830,000 square metres of nature and cropland have been built up in Malta between 2018 and 2023.”

Amphora Media, Green to Grey, 11 September 2026

The press is held to the same standard as everyone else.

Companion piece: “nearly 95%” of it was farmland.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

*Figure stands up,
probably low.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

1.4 km²

Independent estimate

Net new built-up land 2018–2023 in a second 10 m land-cover model.

0.26%

Arithmetic checks out

Share of Malta's land; 116 pitches; about 0.3 of Comino.

65%

Mostly cropland

Independent data; 31% was shrub or grass. Amphora: nearly 95%.

Noisy

Single-year maps mislead

Built-up area swings by 15 km² a year; only consistent change counts.

EEA

Not checked

EEA figures quoted second-hand; “top 5 in Europe” ranking.

FAIR TO SAY

Amphora described its figure as conservative, and the independent data agree. The farmland share needs a stated basis.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ Amphora's map polygons.

☐ Basis of the 95% figure.

☐ EEA land-take data for Malta.

☐ Development-zone status.